
News Release

For Immediate Release – Friday, August 22, 2025

City Perspective Regarding EPA's 5-Year Review

This week the United States Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) released its Five-Year Review of the Cadillac Superfund Site that can be found on the EPA's website at <https://cumulis.epa.gov/supercpad/SiteProfiles/index.cfm?fuseaction=second.scs&id=0502480&doc=Y&colid=39695®ion=05&type=SC>, and the following is an overview.

The cleanup of contamination generated by historical industrial operations at two Superfund sites, undertaken voluntarily by the City's Local Development Finance Authority (LDFA), continues to make significant progress, despite miscellaneous assertions made by several people on social media. To a substantial extent, the assertions recently stirred up by the release of the EPA's Five-Year Review have been previously raised and addressed. Far from causing, contributing, or failing to act on concerns about contamination, the City and its LDFA, which are not responsible parties, have acted responsibly and proactively as issues have emerged.

Although the most recent Five-Year Review offers a limited history, the City submits that its LDFA deserves credit since 1996 in leading the cleanup of hexavalent chromium from the former Northern Plating Superfund site and volatile organic compounds principally from the Kysor Superfund site. Both soil remediation and groundwater treatment have been undertaken through the LDFA, which was formed in the 1990s, as a public-private partnership to facilitate the construction and assist with expenditures for the Superfund cleanup systems.

The City's Utilities Department, in conjunction with the LDFA, has performed operation and maintenance activities for the remedial systems. Other services such as evaluating the effectiveness of the cleanup system and groundwater monitoring have been contracted as necessary. The City most importantly has acted to replace its previous well field with two new well fields and has adopted and amended its ordinances to restrict groundwater usage and facilitate the extension of municipal water to areas near the Superfund sites.

The EPA's Five-Year Review, as it is designed to do, has noted a few challenges with the ongoing cleanup; however, those challenges, despite suggestions to the contrary that frequently become banter on social media, are being addressed:

- Following the discovery of three residential wells being used within a restricted area, the City has connected two of the homes to the municipal water supply, and the third home was demolished. All three residential wells are being abandoned.

- The LDFA is currently working with the EPA and Michigan's Department of Environment, Great Lakes and Energy (EGLE) to restart the groundwater monitoring program. The program was paused as a result of the death of the contractor performing the service, and the EPA's subsequent decision to require new quality assurance project plans (QAPPs) as noted in the Five-Year Review under "miscommunications." The updated testing is scheduled to resume this year with the federal agency approval of the QAPPs.
- Even though prior EGLE testing of certain Superfund site monitoring wells had not shown any exceedances of its criteria for Per- and Polyfluoroalkyl substances (PFAS), the LDFA agreed in 2024 to test certain monitoring wells for PFAS. This decision was made in response to the EPA's insistence for certain monitoring for PFAS before allowing shutdown of the chromium cleanup system. The EPA has required that this PFAS testing of certain wells be done according to EPA QAPP requirements.

As part of the QAPP approval process, the LDFA also has agreed to EPA's recommendation to test for 1, 4-dioxane, even though this emerging contaminant has not been identified as a contaminant caused by the two Superfund sites. In the interim, the City and LDFA have arranged for certain PFAS testing of some monitoring wells and the influent and effluent of the groundwater cleanup system.

PFAS that may be discharging to the Clam River from the treatment system have been found to be below EGLE's surface water criteria. The City and LDFA also have offered to remove and treat potential PFAS contaminated groundwater with the existing carbon treatment system that was used for the chromium cleanup. This offer was made even though the EPA has not determined that any PFAS contamination is due to either Northernaire or Kysor Superfund sites, and even though there is no current use of groundwater in this area for drinking water.

- The City has supported PFAS testing by EGLE of areas outside the zone of contamination for the two Superfund sites. With the discovery of PFAS contamination beyond zones of the Superfund sites, the City has acted to extend its water supply system where it is feasible to do so and is seeking a multi-million-dollar legislative appropriation and grant for a further extension of the system to other areas affected by PFAS contamination.
- The City understands that the LDFA will cooperate in determining the need for repairing and/or installing any damaged monitoring wells. Five out of approximately 200 monitoring wells may need to be repaired or replaced.

Throughout the period monitoring did not occur, the City has continued to operate the carbon treatment and air-stripping cleanup systems and has monitored the influent from recovery wells and the treatment of effluent as part of routine operation and maintenance. Those activities never stopped, and the data from this testing continues to show the absence of hexavalent chromium and a continuing reduction in VOCs.

The City remains committed to supporting the extensive and long-term cleanup of the Northernaire and Kysor Superfund sites, providing clean water to its citizens, and other customers, and assisting its citizens, business and industries. Additionally, the City's drinking water is also regulated, tested, and has never had PFAS detected.

###